The Split-Accumulator Ecosystem

Layer 1
Business Relationships

Health Plan / Insurer

- **Fully-insured:** insurer bears risk
- **Self-insured:** employer bears risk

Plan Sponsor (Employer)

Drug Manufacturer

Copay assistance program

TPA (Third Party Administrator)

PBM (Pharmacy Benefit Manager)

Layer 2
Claim Flow

Medical Claim → **TPA adjudicates** → **Applies Member Cost-Sharing** (deductible, coinsurance, copay) → **TPA Updates Accumulator Record** → **Member / Patient** → **Member visits pharmacy** → **Pharmacy Claim** → **PBM Adjudicates** → **Checks Formulary, Applies Copay** → **PBM Updates Accumulator Record**

TPA Accumulator ⇄ **PBM Accumulator**

Accumulator File Exchange (daily/weekly)

The Split-Accumulator Problem:
Two systems independently tracking the same member's cost-sharing. A $200 pharmacy claim should reduce the member's remaining deductible everywhere, but TPA doesn't know until the next file Exchange.

Layer 3
Where Things Go Wrong

SOURCES OF DISCREPANCY

Timing Gaps
Claim processed Monday, file exchanged Friday. For 4 days, the TPA's accumulator is understated, causing potential member overpayment on medical claims

Copay Card Treatment
Does manufacturer's copay card count toward deductible?

Traditional	Accumulator	Maximizer
Yes	No	PBM inflates copay to extract max manufacturer payment.

Some states ban accumulator programs for fully-insured plans. Self-funded (ERISA) are preempted.

Eligibility Mismatches
Member active in PBM but terminated in TPA (or vice versa), leading to claims processed under wrong eligibility status.

Benefit Year Rollover
New plan year starts Jan 1, accumulator should reset. If rollover fails, previous year's accumulations carry over, causing underpayment or double-counting.

Data Quality
Schema drift, NULL member Ids, duplicate files, stale files past SLA window.

Layer 4
Reconciliation

Monitors / Validates file cycles

PBM SPLIT-ACCUMULATOR RECONCILIATION
Ingest and Align → **Discrepancy Engine** → **Financial Audit**

Operations Team
Fix individual cases, adjust records

- **Findings Registry**
- **Dollar Exposure Quantification**
- **Actionable Remediation Priorities**
- **Plan Sponsor / Compliance**